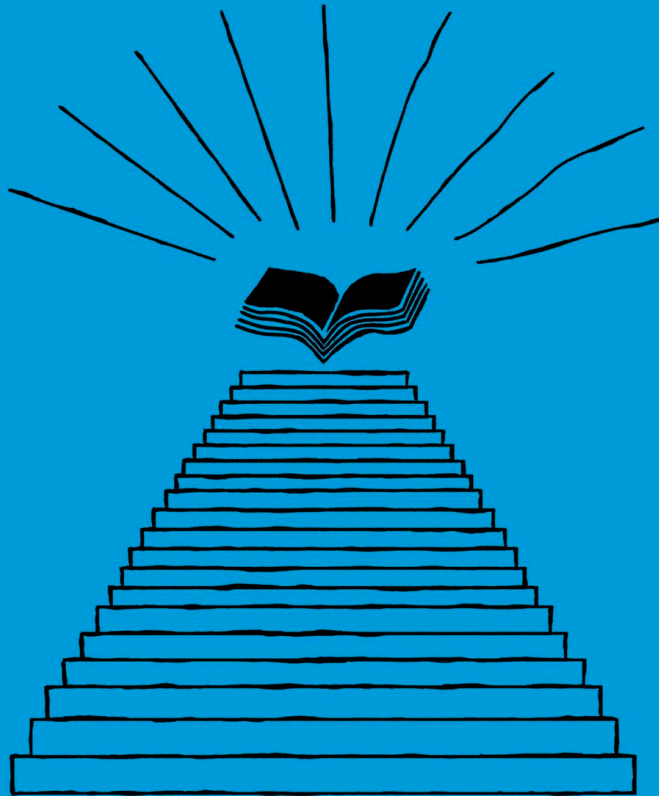


# A DIVINE LAW AND A TRACED-OUT WAY

## THE KORAN (632)



### IN CONTEXT

#### FOCUS

#### Divine law

#### BEFORE

**610–632 CE** The Prophet Muhammad receives the divine revelation of the Koran.

#### AFTER

**c. 660 CE** The first *qadis* or Islamic judges are appointed.

**8th century** Abu Hanifa founds one of the first schools of Islamic jurisprudence.

**c. 840 CE** Muhammad al-Bukhari compiles a definitive collection of *hadith*.

**c. 900 CE** “The gates of *ijtihad*” are declared closed by Islamic legal scholars, ending the practice of independent reasoning by judges.

**I**slamic law arose from a religious revolution. The divine revelation that the Prophet Muhammad received in the early 7th century CE had at its core the oneness of God. It also brought unity to the Arabian Peninsula, which had been fractured both religiously between Jewish and Christian communities and pagan worshippers of many gods, and politically between large numbers of nomadic desert tribes and more settled coastal states.

Although the pre-Islamic period was later characterized as *al-Jahiliyya*, an age of ignorance, it was not entirely without law. Customary law governed the contracts made by merchants trading in coastal and oasis towns—among them the family of Muhammad, from Mecca.